

KAMI

A card game with Mahjong roots

by Angelo Curatolo

A game for 2 or 4 players, ages 10 and up.

Short Game 30–40 minutes / Long Game 60–80 minutes

Inspired by Riichi Mahjong (Japanese Mahjong)

Kami 紙 means “paper” in Japanese — Kami, because this is a game in the Mahjong family played with cards instead of tiles.

This game was designed first and foremost as a 4-player game; the 2-player variant, as well as other variants, are found at the end of this rulebook. These rules may of course still be subject to changes and further tuning.

Feedback welcome: chroniqludiq@gmail.com

This ruleset was originally written in French by the designer. This English translation was produced with the assistance of an AI (Claude, Anthropic).

Acknowledgments

To my wife Brigitte, for her unwavering support.

To Kami's first playtesters: Micheline, Christine, Laure, Brigitte, Anne-Lise, Françoise, Christian, and Adam.

To all the players of the Wim-West-Country-Club in Wimereux.

To the proofreaders: Jonathan Taylor and Murat Briggs.

To Cléo and Zorro, for their steadfast indifference.

Layout and graphics created with the help of AI.

Goal of the Game

Be the first player to build a winning Hand of 11 cards from combinations, in order to steal as many Victory Points as possible from your opponents.

Components

The Suits: ♥, ♦ and ♣, each consisting only of cards numbered 1 to 9 (the Ace counts as 1). Suit cards can be used to form Sequences, Triplets, and Pairs.

The Honours: Jacks (J) and Queens (Q). Honours do not belong to any Suit, even though the ♥, ♦ or ♣ symbols appear on the cards — these symbols are used only to distinguish the different Jacks and Queens. Honours can only be used to form Triplets or Pairs.

Important: in Kami, a Jack or Queen never comes after the 9 and can never be part of a Sequence.

- Four standard decks of playing cards, preferably Bridge-size, are needed to assemble this set of 132 cards.
- Tokens: four tokens worth 10, eight tokens worth 5, thirty-two tokens worth 1, and sixteen tokens worth ½. Mahjong sticks are ideal; poker chips work perfectly well too — or any other tokens you find suitable.
- One First Player token.

Setup

- All players shuffle the cards together, face down, in the middle of the table.
- Remove 10 cards face down from the shuffled cards. Set these ten cards aside, still face down, for now. They form the “Dead Leaf Pile.”
- Divide the remaining shuffled cards into 4 roughly equal face-down piles and place them in the center of the table in a cross. These four piles form the Forest.
- Each player has a personal discard pile in front of the Forest pile facing them.
- Place the “Dead Leaf Pile” at the center of the Forest. Turn its top card face up; it becomes the “Trump Indicator.”



The Forest, set up as a cross of four piles, with the Trump Indicator revealed at the center. Photo by Angelo Curatolo.

The Trump

The Trump card is the card immediately above the Trump Indicator, in the same suit. If the Trump Indicator is the 6♥, the Trump will be the card directly above it — in this case the 7♥. And if the Trump Indicator is a 9♥, the Trump will be a 1♥.

For Honors, simply follow this suit order: ♥ → ♦ → ♣. So if the Trump Indicator is Q♥, the Trump will be Q♦. And if the Trump Indicator is J♣, the Trump will be J♥.

Each Trump card in the Winning Hand is worth 1 extra point.

Example: if the Trump is the 7♥ and your winning hand contains two 7♥, you score +2pts (1pt per card).

First Player and Dealing

- Randomly determine a first player. This player receives the First Player token and becomes the player in first position. The player to their left becomes the player in second position, and so on.
- Starting with the player in first position, then continuing with positions 2, 3 and 4, each player draws 4 cards, one from each of the 4 piles, starting with the one in front of them and continuing clockwise. Repeat this a second time. To finish, each player draws two more cards: one from the pile in front of them, and one from the pile to their left. Each player ends up with ten cards in hand. Do not reveal these to the other players.
- Choose a “Combinations Sheet” (Casual, for Initiates, for Champions, or for Masters), and distribute the Starting Point Capital as indicated on the sheet. Each player places all their tokens to their left; this is the spot reserved for them until the end of the game.

You are now ready to play.

The Hand

As a prerequisite, a hand must always contain three 3-card elements and one 2-card element. These elements can each be made up of either a Run of three cards, or a Triplet — and finally, a Pair. Each element must be made using cards of one single suit.

ex: 2♥3♥4♥ 3♣4♣5♣ 4♦4♦4♦ 6♣6♣

In addition to this prerequisite, a hand must also contain a combination or “Key” (see the detailed list of combinations later in this rulebook). A few Hands are exceptions to this rule.

Building a Hand

Each set must use cards of a single suit. Suit cards can form Sequences, Triplets, or Pairs; Honours (J, Q) can only form Triplets or Pairs.



Sequence



Triplet



Sequence



Pair

3 sets of 3 cards (Sequence or Triplet) + 1 Pair = 11 cards

The Turn Jack

The Turn Jack is the Jack bearing the same symbol (♥, ♦ or ♣) as the Trump Indicator. Example: if the Trump Indicator is 6♥ or Q♥, the Turn Jack is J♥.

Exception: if the Trump Indicator is itself a Jack, there is no Turn Jack for that round — the indicated Jack cannot be used to score a Favour as the Turn Jack.

The Position

A “Position” Triplet is determined by the player's position at the table during the current hand. For a player in Position 1, a Triplet of 1s. Same for Positions 2, 3, and 4. The suit does not matter, only the number counts.

Turn of Play

- On their turn, each player draws a card from the Forest, then discards a card face up onto their discard pile.
- Players play clockwise.
- Players start by drawing from the pile in front of the player in first position at the start of the hand; once that pile is exhausted, they continue drawing from the next pile clockwise.
- Each card discarded by a player must remain visible in front of them. Discarded cards are stacked to save space, in rows of six cards.



Example of the four players' personal discard piles during play. Photo by Angelo Curatolo.

Capture and the “I Take It!” Call

A card that has just been discarded by a player may be captured by another player only at the precise moment it is discarded. If the next player has already started their turn by drawing their card, it is too late. To capture a discarded card, simply call out “I take it!”

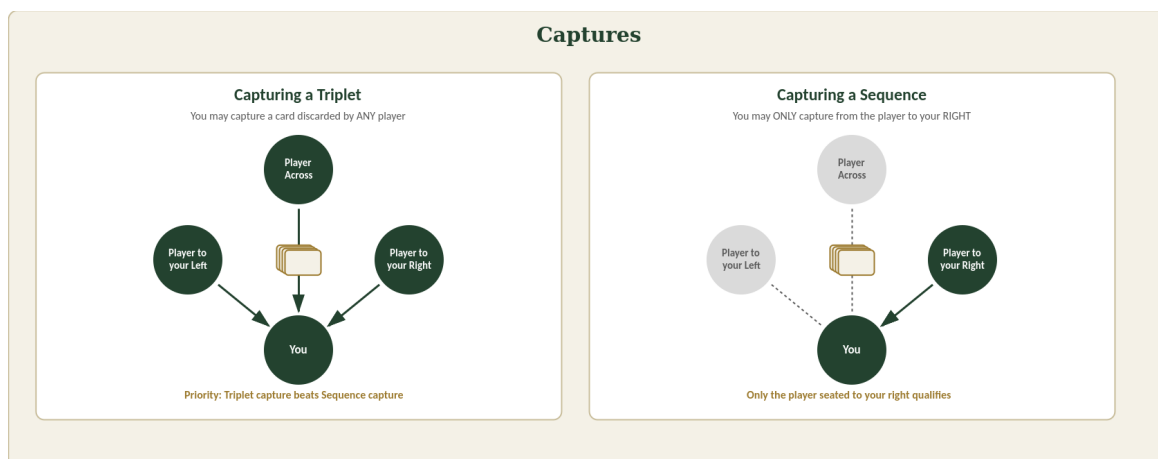
If several players call “I take it!”, priority goes first to Triplet, then to Run. Otherwise, priority goes to the player closest, clockwise, to the player who just discarded. A player capturing to complete their Hand and end the Hand always has absolute priority.

Capture procedure

- Triplet: to complete a Triplet, you may capture a card discarded by any player.
- Run: to complete a Run, you may only capture a card discarded by the player to your right.

In both cases, the capturing player calls “I take it!”, reveals the two cards from their hand that complete the element, adds the captured card to them, and places the whole (Triplet or Run) to their right. They must then

discard a card from their hand. The player to their left then begins their turn directly — some players may therefore see their turn skipped.



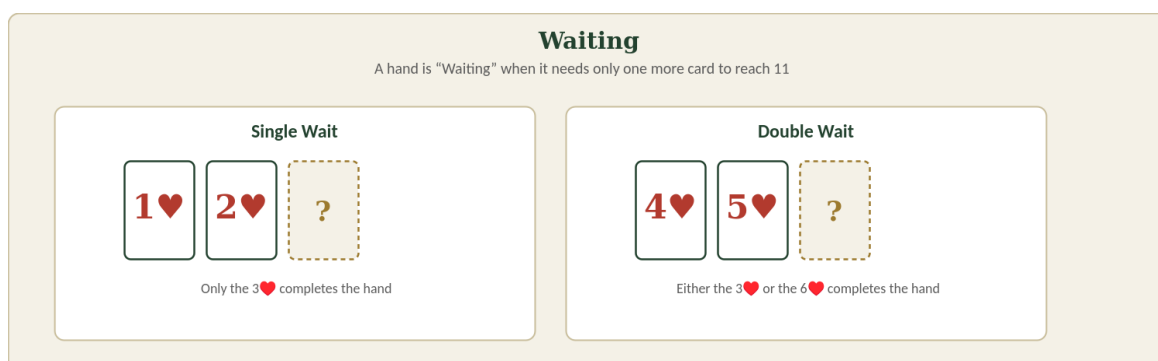
Open Hand and Closed Hand

- Open Hand: a player's hand is said to be “Open” as soon as they capture a card from an opponent and place the resulting element (Run or Triplet) on the table.
- Closed Hand: a player's hand is said to be “Closed” as long as they have not placed an element on the table (Run or Triplet).

Waiting

A Hand is said to be Waiting when it needs only one more card to become a complete 11-card Winning Hand.

- Single wait: only one card can complete the Hand.
- Double wait: two cards can complete the Hand. Example: with an incomplete 2♥3♥ element, either 1♥ or 4♥ can complete the Sequence — the Hand still needs only one card, but two cards can complete it.

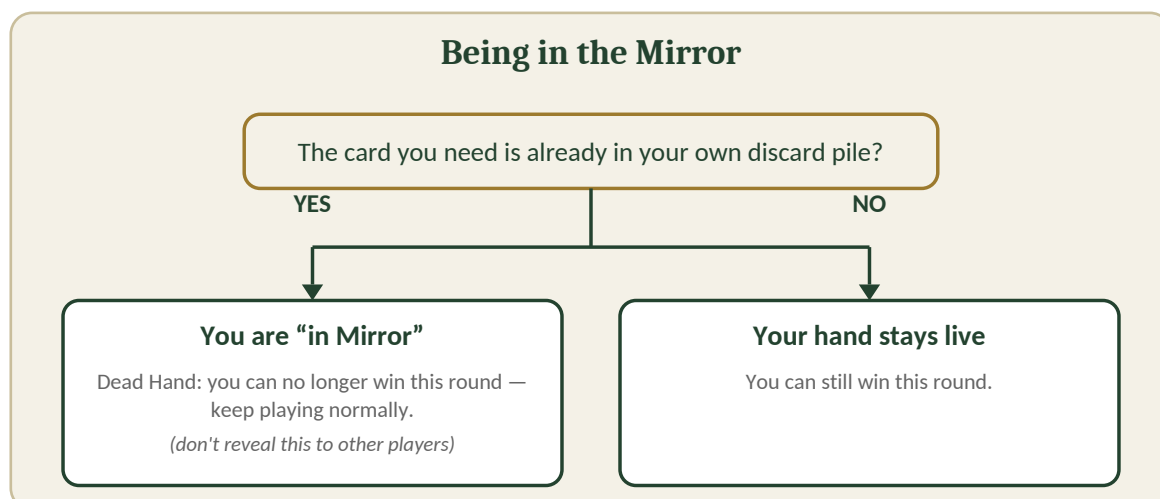


Being in the Mirror

A player is considered « in Mirror » when all the cards that could complete their Hand are already present in their own discard pile.

With a Single Wait, if the only card that can complete the Hand is present in the player's discard pile, the player is in Mirror. With a Double Wait, the player is in Mirror only if both cards that could complete the Hand are present in their discard pile; if only one of the two is present, the Hand remains live thanks to the other card.

A player who is in Mirror is Out of Play and has a « Dead Hand ». They continue to play normally, but can no longer complete their Hand during that round. They must not reveal their Dead Hand status to the other players.



The Kami

The “Kami” is a way of completing a hand by making a bet. When a player is “Waiting” — meaning they need only one more card to complete their hand — they may (it is not mandatory) declare a “Kami.” To do so, at the end of their turn, after discarding their card:

- They announce “Kami,” take a 1pt token from their reserve, and place it in front of them. This declaration requires a closed hand.
- On their following turns, they may only draw, hoping to draw their missing card, or hoping another player discards it.
- Several players may declare “Kami” during the same hand.

Important rule and exception:

Kami can only be declared if, at that moment, the awaited card — or at least one of the awaited cards, in case of a multiple wait — is not present in any discard pile.

Since Kami is itself a Key, no other Key is required to declare Kami and complete a Winning Hand.

Completing Your Hand and Winning the Round

Victory by Draw

When a player is Waiting (missing only one card) and draws the 11th winning card, they announce “Served!” and reveal their hand. This ends the round and triggers a count of Victory Points followed by a payment of Points.

Victory by Capture

When a player is Waiting (missing only one card) and captures the 11th winning card discarded by any player, they announce “Thank you!” and reveal their hand. This ends the round and triggers a count of Victory Points followed by a payment of Points.

Precision: a player with an Open hand (having already claimed one or more cards during the round) retains the right to win by claiming a discarded card. As soon as they are only one card short of completing their 11-card hand, they may call “Thank you!” the moment an opponent discards that missing card. However, because their hand is Open, they are permanently barred from declaring KAMI.

Payment of Points

After calculating the value of the winning Hand, the winner receives that number of Points from the other players.

SERVED! — Win by Draw

The three other players share the payment as evenly as possible. Each player first pays the same amount, in increments of $\frac{1}{2}$ Point. If $\frac{1}{2}$ Point or 1 Point still remains to be paid, the remainder is paid in turn order, starting with the player to the winner's left.

- Hand worth 2 Points: each player pays $\frac{1}{2}$ Point, then the player to the winner's left pays the remaining $\frac{1}{2}$ Point.
- Hand worth 1 Point: the first two players to the winner's left each pay $\frac{1}{2}$ Point. The third player pays nothing.

THANK YOU! — Win by Capture

It's even simpler: the player who discarded the winning card pays the full amount of the Points alone.

Special Cases

- +1pt for each Trump card present in the completed hand.
- In the case of “Kami”: if the player who declared “Kami” wins the round, they recover their staked point. If another player wins the round, that player wins the staked point. If no one wins the round, the stake remains on the table and will be won by the player who wins the next round.

When a player succeeds with their “Kami” and wins the round, they reveal one “Under Indicator” card from the “Dead Leaf Pile.” The card immediately above it, in the same suit, becomes the “Under Trump” (same rule as the Trump). They add points for each Under Trump card in their hand. Example: Trump Indicator = 6♥ (Trump = 7♥); winning by Kami reveals 3♣ as Under Indicator, so Under Trump = 4♣. Each 4♣ in hand = +1pt.

End of Round

- When a player wins the round by completing a Winning Hand with an 11th card.
- When a player draws the last card of the Forest without anyone completing their hand. In this case, each player reveals their hand. Players who are “Waiting” (missing only one card) share a 3pt bonus, paid by the players who are not Waiting:
 - 1 player Waiting: the other 3 pay them 1pt.
 - 2 players Waiting: each of the 2 non-Waiting players pays 1.5pt total, split equally between the Waiting players.
 - 3 players Waiting: the remaining player pays them 1pt each.
 - 4 players Waiting: no one pays.

Preparing the Next Round

Gather all the cards face down in the middle of the table and shuffle them all together. Remove 10 cards to form the Dead Leaf Pile. Rebuild the Forest and place the Dead Leaf Pile at its center, with the Trump Indicator revealed. Pass the First Player token to the player to the left of the current first player.

End of Game

- Half-Game or Short Game: when all players have been in First Position once.
- Full Game or Long Game: when all players have been in First Position twice.
- The Game also ends if a player has no points left at all at the end of a round, having exhausted all their points in a payment.

In all cases, the player with the most points in their reserve wins the game. In case of a tie, the players share the victory.

Combinations “Keys” and Points

The game offers four Combinations Sheets of increasing depth. Each higher version includes all combinations from the previous versions.

Combinations “Keys” and Points — “for Casual” Version

Starting Capital: 5 Points (3 × 1pt, 4 × ½ pt).

Each combination present in the winning hand earns a fixed number of points. These combinations can be stacked with one another. O/C: Open or Closed Hand. C: Closed Hand required. O: Open Hand required. All O/C combinations earn 1pt extra if achieved with a Closed Hand, with the exception of the Stream and the Favors.

Winning Draw — 1pt (Closed Hand required)

Draw the winning card.

The Favors — 1pt (Open or Closed Hand)

A Triplet of Queens / or a Triplet of the Turn Jack (same suit as the Trump) / or a Triplet of your Position. (All stack together.) No Bonus for Closed Hand.

The Stream — 1pt (Open or Closed Hand)

A hand made up only of cards from 2 to 8. No Bonus for Closed Hand.

ex: 2♦3♦4♦ 4♣5♣6♣ 5♦6♦7♦ 2♥2♥

The Small Path — 1pt (Open or Closed Hand)

A Run in two identical copies.

ex: 1♥2♥3♥ 1♥2♥3♥ 4♦4♦4♦ Q♣Q♣

The Two Oaks — 1pt (Open or Closed Hand)

The same Triplet in two suits.

ex: 3♥3♥3♥ 3♣3♣3♣ 4♦4♦4♦ Q♣Q♣

The Kami — 2pts (Closed Hand required)

Declare “Kami” by staking 1pt (the hand must be Waiting). Kami can only be declared if, at that moment, the awaited card — or at least one of the awaited cards, in case of a multiple wait — is not present in any discard pile.

The Oak Grove — 2pts (Open or Closed Hand)

Only Triplets. (*Open Hand required in the Masters version.)

+1pt per Trump card present in the hand. • +1pt per Under Indicator card present in the hand — only on a Kami victory.

Example 1 — One combination

Hand: 2♥ 3♥ 4♥ / 4♣ 5♣ 6♣ / 5♦ 6♦ 7♦ / 2♥ 2♥ — Victory by Capture (“Thank you!”).

Combination: The Stream (only cards from 2 to 8) — 1pt. Total: 1 point.

Example 2 — Two combinations (with Kami)

Waiting hand: 3♥ 4♥ 5♥ / 6♣ 7♣ 8♣ / 8♦ 8♦ 8♦ / 9♦ (waiting on the second 9♦). Stakes 1pt, declares “Kami”, draws the missing 9♦ : “Served!”

Combinations: The Kami 2pts — Winning Draw 1pt. Total: 3 points (+ recovery of the 1pt stake).

Example 3 — Three combinations (with Kami)

Waiting hand: 1♥ 2♥ 3♥ / 1♥ 2♥ 3♥ / 4♦ 4♦ 4♦ / J♣ (waiting on the second J♣). Stakes 1pt, declares “Kami”, draws the missing J♣ : “Served!”

Combinations: The Small Path (closed) 2pts — The Kami 2pts — Winning Draw 1pt. Total: 5 points (+ recovery of the 1pt stake).

Example 4 — With Trump

Same hand as Example 3, but the Trump Indicator = 3♦ → the Trump is the 4♦. The hand contains three 4♦ (the Triplet).

Combinations: The Small Path (closed) 2pts — The Kami 2pts — Winning Draw 1pt — Trump (3 cards) +3pts. Total: 8 points (+ recovery of the 1pt stake).

Combinations “Keys” and Points — “for Initiates” Version

Starting Capital: 10 Points ($8 \times 1\text{pt}$, $4 \times \frac{1}{2}\text{pt}$).

Each combination present in the winning hand earns a fixed number of points. These combinations can be stacked with one another. O/C: Open or Closed Hand. C: Closed Hand required. O: Open Hand required. All O/C combinations earn 1pt extra if achieved with a Closed Hand, with the exception of the Stream and the Favors.

Winning Draw — 1pt (Closed Hand required)

Draw the winning card.

The Favors — 1pt (Open or Closed Hand)

A Triplet of Queens / or a Triplet of the Turn Jack (same suit as the Trump) / or a Triplet of your Position. (All stack together.) No Bonus for Closed Hand.

The Stream — 1pt (Open or Closed Hand)

A hand made up only of cards from 2 to 8. No Bonus for Closed Hand.

ex: $2\heartsuit 3\heartsuit 4\heartsuit$ $4\clubsuit 5\clubsuit 6\clubsuit$ $5\diamondsuit 6\diamondsuit 7\diamondsuit$ $2\heartsuit 2\heartsuit$

The Small Path — 1pt (Open or Closed Hand)

A Run in two identical copies.

ex: $1\heartsuit 2\heartsuit 3\heartsuit$ $1\heartsuit 2\heartsuit 3\heartsuit$ $4\diamondsuit 4\diamondsuit 4\diamondsuit$ $Q\clubsuit Q\clubsuit$

The Two Oaks — 1pt (Open or Closed Hand)

The same Triplet in two suits.

ex: $3\heartsuit 3\heartsuit 3\heartsuit$ $3\clubsuit 3\clubsuit 3\clubsuit$ $4\diamondsuit 4\diamondsuit 4\diamondsuit$ $Q\clubsuit Q\clubsuit$

The Kami — 2pts (Closed Hand required)

Declare “Kami” by staking 1pt (the hand must be Waiting). Kami can only be declared if, at that moment, the awaited card — or at least one of the awaited cards, in case of a multiple wait — is not present in any discard pile.

The Oak Grove — 2pts (Open or Closed Hand)

Only Triplets. (*Open Hand required in the Masters version.)

The River — 1pt (Closed Hand required)

Runs only, double wait, ordinary pair. (A Double Wait is when the missing card can be one of two cards that complete a Run — e.g. with $2\heartsuit 3\heartsuit$ in hand, either $1\heartsuit$ or $4\heartsuit$ completes it.)

The Two Maples — 2pts (Open or Closed Hand)

Two Concealed Triplets (the rest of the hand may be open).

Left Bank Right Bank — 2pts (Open or Closed Hand)

Every element of the hand contains Terminals or Honors.

ex: $1\heartsuit 2\heartsuit 3\heartsuit$ $7\clubsuit 8\clubsuit 9\clubsuit$ $Q\heartsuit Q\heartsuit Q\heartsuit$ $9\clubsuit 9\clubsuit$

The 5 Pairs — 3pts (Closed Hand required)

5 pairs + one card identical to a card in one of the Pairs.

ex: $1\heartsuit 1\heartsuit$ $J\clubsuit J\clubsuit$ $5\clubsuit 5\clubsuit$ $9\diamondsuit 9\diamondsuit$ $6\heartsuit 6\heartsuit$ $5\clubsuit$

+1pt per Trump card present in the hand. • +1pt per Under Indicator card present in the hand — only on a Kami victory.

Example 1 — One combination

Hand: $1\heartsuit 2\heartsuit 3\heartsuit$ / $7\clubsuit 8\clubsuit 9\clubsuit$ / $J\diamondsuit J\diamondsuit J\diamondsuit$ / $9\clubsuit 9\clubsuit$ — Victory by Capture (“Thank you!”).

Combination: Left Bank Right Bank — 2pts. Total: 2 points.

Example 2 — Two combinations (with Kami)

Waiting hand: $4\diamondsuit 5\diamondsuit 6\diamondsuit$ / $1\clubsuit 2\clubsuit 3\clubsuit$ / $8\heartsuit 8\heartsuit 8\heartsuit$ / $6\heartsuit$ (waiting on the second $6\heartsuit$). Stakes 1pt, declares “Kami”, draws the missing $6\heartsuit$: “Served!”

Combinations: The Kami 2pts — Winning Draw 1pt. Total: 3 points (+ recovery of the 1pt stake).

Example 3 — Three combinations (with Kami)

Waiting hand: $2\heartsuit 3\heartsuit 4\heartsuit$ / $5\diamondsuit 6\diamondsuit 7\diamondsuit$ / $7\clubsuit 8\clubsuit$ / $4\clubsuit 4\clubsuit$ (double wait: $6\clubsuit$ or $9\clubsuit$). Stakes 1pt, declares “Kami”, draws the $9\clubsuit$: “Served!”

Combinations: The River 1pt — The Kami 2pts — Winning Draw 1pt. Total: 4 points (+ recovery of the 1pt stake).

Example 4 — With Trump

Same hand as Example 3, but the Trump Indicator = 1♥ → the Trump is the 2♥. The hand contains one 2♥.

Combinations: The River 1pt — The Kami 2pts — Winning Draw 1pt — Trump (1 card) +1pt. Total: 5 points (+ recovery of the 1pt stake).

Combinations “Keys” and Points — “for Champions” Version

Starting Capital: 15 Points ($1 \times 5\text{pts}$, $8 \times 1\text{pt}$, $4 \times \frac{1}{2}\text{pt}$).

Each combination present in the winning hand earns a fixed number of points. These combinations can be stacked with one another. O/C: Open or Closed Hand. C: Closed Hand required. O: Open Hand required. All O/C combinations earn 1pt extra if achieved with a Closed Hand, with the exception of the Stream and the Favors.

Stacking exception: the Small Path and the Long Path never stack together.

Winning Draw — 1pt (Closed Hand required)

Draw the winning card.

The Favors — 1pt (Open or Closed Hand)

A Triplet of Queens / or a Triplet of the Turn Jack (same suit as the Trump) / or a Triplet of your Position. (All stack together.) No Bonus for Closed Hand.

The Stream — 1pt (Open or Closed Hand)

A hand made up only of cards from 2 to 8. No Bonus for Closed Hand.

ex: $2\heartsuit 3\heartsuit 4\heartsuit$ $4\clubsuit 5\clubsuit 6\clubsuit$ $5\diamondsuit 6\diamondsuit 7\diamondsuit$ $2\heartsuit 2\heartsuit$

The Small Path — 1pt (Open or Closed Hand)

A Run in two identical copies.

ex: $1\heartsuit 2\heartsuit 3\heartsuit$ $1\heartsuit 2\heartsuit 3\heartsuit$ $4\diamondsuit 4\diamondsuit 4\diamondsuit$ $Q\clubsuit Q\clubsuit$

The Two Oaks — 1pt (Open or Closed Hand)

The same Triplet in two suits.

ex: $3\heartsuit 3\heartsuit 3\heartsuit$ $3\clubsuit 3\clubsuit 3\clubsuit$ $4\diamondsuit 4\diamondsuit 4\diamondsuit$ $Q\clubsuit Q\clubsuit$

The Kami — 2pts (Closed Hand required)

Declare “Kami” by staking 1pt (the hand must be Waiting). Kami can only be declared if, at that moment, the awaited card — or at least one of the awaited cards, in case of a multiple wait — is not present in any discard pile.

The Oak Grove — 2pts (Open or Closed Hand)

Only Triplets. (*Open Hand required in the Masters version.)

The River — 1pt (Closed Hand required)

Runs only, double wait, ordinary pair. (A Double Wait is when the missing card can be one of two cards that complete a Run — e.g. with $2\heartsuit \heartsuit$ in hand, either $1\heartsuit$ or $4\heartsuit$ completes it.)

The Two Maples — 2pts (Open or Closed Hand)

Two Concealed Triplets (the rest of the hand may be open).

Left Bank Right Bank — 2pts (Open or Closed Hand)

Every element of the hand contains Terminals or Honors.

ex: $1\heartsuit 2\heartsuit 3\heartsuit$ $7\clubsuit 8\clubsuit 9\clubsuit$ $Q\heartsuit Q\heartsuit Q\heartsuit$ $9\clubsuit 9\clubsuit$

The 5 Pairs — 3pts (Closed Hand required)

5 pairs + one card identical to a card in one of the Pairs.

ex: $1\heartsuit 1\heartsuit$ $J\clubsuit J\clubsuit$ $5\clubsuit 5\clubsuit$ $9\diamondsuit 9\diamondsuit$ $6\heartsuit 6\heartsuit$ $5\clubsuit$

The Apples Pears — 2pts (Open or Closed Hand)

A single suit plus Honors.

ex: $1\heartsuit 2\heartsuit 3\heartsuit$ $9\heartsuit 9\heartsuit 9\heartsuit$ $Q\diamondsuit Q\diamondsuit Q\diamondsuit$ $8\heartsuit 8\heartsuit$

The Prestige — 3pts (Open or Closed Hand)

Only Terminals or Honors.

ex: $1\diamondsuit 1\diamondsuit 1\diamondsuit$ $9\clubsuit 9\clubsuit 9\clubsuit$ $J\diamondsuit J\diamondsuit J\diamondsuit$ $Q\heartsuit Q\heartsuit$

The Winding Path — 3pts (Open or Closed Hand)

The same Run in three suits.

ex: $1\heartsuit 2\heartsuit 3\heartsuit$ $1\clubsuit 2\clubsuit 3\clubsuit$ $1\diamondsuit 2\diamondsuit 3\diamondsuit$ $4\clubsuit 4\clubsuit$

The Long Path — 3pts (Open or Closed Hand)

A Run in two identical copies + the same Run in another suit.

ex: 1♥2♥3♥ 1♥2♥3♥ 1♣2♣3♣ 4♣4♣

The Great Road — 3pts (Open or Closed Hand)

123456789 in a single suit + any pair.

+1pt per Trump card present in the hand. • +1pt per Under Indicator card present in the hand — only on a Kami victory.

Example 1 — One combination

Hand: 4♥5♥6♥ / 4♦5♦6♦ / 4♣5♣6♣ / 9♥9♥ — Victory by Capture (“Thank you!”).

Combination: The Winding Path (the same Run in three suits) — 3pts. Total: 3 points.

Example 2 — Two combinations (with Kami)

Waiting hand: 2♣3♣4♣ / 5♦6♦7♦ / J♥J♥J♥ / 8♣ (waiting on the second 8♣). Stakes 1pt, declares “Kami”, draws the missing 8♣: “Served!”

Combinations: The Kami 2pts — Winning Draw 1pt. Total: 3 points (+ recovery of the 1pt stake).

Example 3 — Three combinations (with Kami)

Waiting hand: 3♦4♦5♦ / 6♦7♦8♦ / J♦J♦J♦ / Q♦ (waiting on the second Q♦). Stakes 1pt, declares “Kami”, draws the missing Q♦: “Served!”

Combinations: The Apples Pears (closed) 3pts — The Kami 2pts — Winning Draw 1pt. Total: 6 points (+ recovery of the 1pt stake).

Example 4 — With Trump

Same hand as Example 3, but the Trump Indicator = 2♦ → the Trump is the 3♦, and the Trump suit is Diamonds → the Turn Jack becomes J♦. The hand contains one 3♦ (Trump) and a Triplet of J♦ (Favors: Triplet of the Turn Jack).

Combinations: The Apples Pears (closed) 3pts — The Kami 2pts — Winning Draw 1pt — The Favors 1pt — Trump (1 card) +1pt. Total: 8 points (+ recovery of the 1pt stake).

Combinations “Keys” and Points — “for Masters” Version

Starting Capital: 20 Points (2 × 5pts, 8 × 1pt, 4 × ½ pt).

Each combination present in the winning hand earns a fixed number of points. These combinations can be stacked with one another. O/C: Open or Closed Hand. C: Closed Hand required. O: Open Hand required. All O/C combinations earn 1pt extra if achieved with a Closed Hand, with the exception of the Stream and the Favors.

Stacking exception: the Small Path and the Long Path never stack together. Likewise, the Apples Pears and the Hearts / Silver / Earth Hands never stack with each other.

Winning Draw — 1pt (Closed Hand required)

Draw the winning card.

The Favors — 1pt (Open or Closed Hand)

A Triplet of Queens / or a Triplet of the Turn Jack (same suit as the Trump) / or a Triplet of your Position. (All stack together.) No Bonus for Closed Hand.

The Stream — 1pt (Open or Closed Hand)

A hand made up only of cards from 2 to 8. No Bonus for Closed Hand.

ex: 2♦3♦4♦ 4♠5♠6♠ 5♦6♦7♦ 2♥2♥

The Small Path — 1pt (Open or Closed Hand)

A Run in two identical copies.

ex: 1♥2♥3♥ 1♥2♥3♥ 4♦4♦4♦ Q♣Q♣

The Two Oaks — 1pt (Open or Closed Hand)

The same Triplet in two suits.

ex: 3♥3♥3♥ 3♠3♠3♠ 4♦4♦4♦ Q♣Q♣

The Kami — 2pts (Closed Hand required)

Declare “Kami” by staking 1pt (the hand must be Waiting). Kami can only be declared if, at that moment, the awaited card — or at least one of the awaited cards, in case of a multiple wait — is not present in any discard pile.

The Oak Grove — 2pts (Open or Closed Hand)

Only Triplets. (*Open Hand required in the Masters version.)

The River — 1pt (Closed Hand required)

Runs only, double wait, ordinary pair. (A Double Wait is when the missing card can be one of two cards that complete a Run — e.g. with 2♥ 3♥ in hand, either 1♥ or 4♥ completes it.)

The Two Maples — 2pts (Open or Closed Hand)

Two Concealed Triplets (the rest of the hand may be open).

Left Bank Right Bank — 2pts (Open or Closed Hand)

Every element of the hand contains Terminals or Honors.

ex: 1♥2♥3♥ 7♠8♠9♠ Q♥Q♥Q♥ 9♣9♣

The 5 Pairs — 3pts *(Closed Hand required)*

5 pairs + one card identical to a card in one of the Pairs.

ex: 1♥1♥ J♣J♣ 5♠5♠ 9♦9♦ 6♥6♥ 5♣

The Apples Pears — 2pts *(Open or Closed Hand)*

A single suit plus Honors.

ex: 1♥2♥3♥ 9♥9♥9♥ Q♦Q♦Q♦ 8♥8♥

The Prestige — 3pts *(Open or Closed Hand)*

Only Terminals or Honors.

ex: 1♦1♦1♦ 9♠9♠9♠ J♦J♦J♦ Q♥Q♥

The Winding Path — 3pts *(Open or Closed Hand)*

The same Run in three suits.

ex: 1♥2♥3♥ 1♠2♠3♠ 1♦2♦3♦ 4♣4♣

The Long Path — 3pts *(Open or Closed Hand)*

A Run in two identical copies + the same Run in another suit.

ex: 1♥2♥3♥ 1♥2♥3♥ 1♠2♠3♠ 4♣4♣

The Great Road — 3pts *(Open or Closed Hand)*

123456789 in a single suit + any pair.

The Small Jack — 4pts *(Open or Closed Hand)*

Two Triplets of Jacks + a pair of the third.

The Small Queen — 4pts *(Open or Closed Hand)*

Two Triplets of Queens + a pair of the third.

The Maple Grove — 6pts *(Closed Hand required)*

Three Concealed Triplets.

Grand Hands

The Hearts Hand — 5pts *(Open or Closed Hand)*

A hand made only of cards from the Hearts suit (no Honors).

The Silver Hand — 5pts *(Open or Closed Hand)*

A hand made only of cards from the Diamonds suit (no Honors).

The Earth Hand — 5pts *(Open or Closed Hand)*

A hand made only of cards from the Clubs suit (no Honors).

The Grand Queen — 10pts *(Open or Closed Hand)*

A Triplet of each Queen.

The Grand Jack — 10pts (Open or Closed Hand)

A Triplet of each Jack.

The Grand Prestige — 10pts (Open or Closed Hand)

Only Terminals.

ex: 1♥1♥1♥ 9♦9♦9♦ 9♥9♥9♥ 1♣1♣

The Court — 10pts (Open or Closed Hand)

Only Honors.

ex: Q♣Q♣Q♣ J♥J♥J♥ J♦J♦J♦ Q♥Q♥

The Council of Sages — 10pts (Closed Hand required)

Ten different cards among the 12 Terminals/Honors + one Double.

ex: Q♥J♥1♦9♦1♠9♠Q♣J♣1♥9♥Q♥

Kamiwaza 神業 — 15pts (Open or Closed Hand)

Cards from a single suit (including Honors) with the following cards: 1♣ 2♣ 3♣ 4♣ 5♣ 6♣ 7♣ 8♣ 9♣ J♣ Q♣ .

Kami no Kumon 神の九門 — 15pts (Open or Closed Hand)

Cards from a single suit with the following cards: 1♥ 1♥ 2♥ 3♥ 4♥ 5♥ 6♥ 7♥ 8♥ 9♥ 9♥ .

+1pt per Trump card present in the hand. • +1pt per Under Indicator card present in the hand — only on a Kami victory.

Example 1 — One combination

Hand: 2♥ 3♥ 4♥ / 5♥ 6♥ 7♥ / 8♥ 8♥ 8♥ / 9♥ 9♥ — Victory by Capture (“Thank you!”).

Combination: The Hearts Hand (only cards from the Hearts suit, no Honors) — 5pts. Total: 5 points.

Example 2 — Two combinations (with Kami)

Waiting hand: 1♣ 2♣ 3♣ / 7♦ 8♦ 9♦ / 3♥ 3♥ 3♥ / 5♣ (waiting on the second 5♣). Stakes 1pt, declares “Kami”, draws the missing 5♣ : “Served!”

Combinations: The Kami 2pts — Winning Draw 1pt. Total: 3 points (+ recovery of the 1pt stake).

Example 3 — Three combinations (with Kami)

Waiting hand: 3♥ 3♥ 3♥ / 7♦ 7♦ 7♦ / 2♣ 3♣ 4♣ / 9♣ (waiting on the second 9♣) — both Triplets built entirely by drawing (Concealed). Stakes 1pt, declares “Kami”, draws the missing 9♣ : “Served!”

Combinations: The Two Maples (closed) 3pts — The Kami 2pts — Winning Draw 1pt. Total: 6 points (+ recovery of the 1pt stake).

Example 4 — With Trump

Same hand as Example 3, but the Trump Indicator = 2♥ → the Trump is the 3♥ . The hand contains three 3♥ (the first Triplet).

Combinations: The Two Maples (closed) 3pts — The Kami 2pts — Winning Draw 1pt — Trump (3 cards) +3pts. Total: 9 points (+ recovery of the 1pt stake).

Two-Player Variant

Setup

Proceed as for the 4-player version; however, remove 30 cards face down to create the “Dead Leaf Pile.” Players sit facing each other. Players in the 2nd and 4th Position are always ghost players.

Randomly determine a first player. This player is considered to be in first position, and the other player in third position. Players swap positions after each round. All other rules remain unchanged.

However, after finishing their turn by discarding a card, the player whose turn it is draws one more card from the “Forest” and discards it onto the discard pile of the ghost player (in position 2 or 4) to their left. This card may be captured like any other discarded card.

In the event of a Drawn Victory (“Served!”), payment is made in the same way as in a four-player game. The two ghost players are treated as players for the purpose of splitting the payment; their share is paid by the Bank.

In the event of a Capture Victory (“Thank you!”), the usual rule remains unchanged: the player who discarded the winning card pays the full number of Points. If the winning card comes from a ghost player's discard pile, the full number of Points is paid by the Bank.

If the Round ends without either opponent completing their hand, and one of them is Waiting, the other must pay them one point. If both opponents are Waiting, no points are paid. Ghost players never receive points — they have no Hand at all, just a discard pile.

- Short Game: each player plays twice in First Position.
- Long Game: each player plays four times in First Position.

Other Variants

The Exploding Queen

When a Queen Triplet is completed by Capture, immediately reveal a new “Trump Indicator” from the “Dead Leaf Pile.” There can therefore be up to 4 Trumps in play. If a player wins the Round by Kami, reveal as many Under Indicators as there are Trump Indicators.

(Each revealed Trump Indicator determines its own Under Trump the same way.)

The Quads

You may now form Quads, either by drawing or by capturing. If you form a Quad by drawing, you must lay it on the table — thereby opening your hand — for it to be considered a Quad (you are not obligated to do so). Although made up of 4 cards, a Quad is always considered a three-card element. Whether the Quad is formed by drawing or by capturing, you do not discard any card: your hand remains at 10 cards once the Quad is revealed. Thanks to your Quad, the next player then benefits from an extra draw from the “Dead Leaf Pile,” followed by a discard, before beginning their turn.

Each Quad grants you 2 extra points if you win the Round.

The Jokers

Preparation: remove one 5 of each suit before adding three Jokers to the deck. A Joker is considered to be a 5 of any suit. It can be captured as a 5 of any suit. A Joker can never be part of a Pair.

Each Joker in your hand grants 1 extra point if you win the Round.

The Dry Stream

The “Stream” combination can now only be completed with a Closed Hand.

Appendix — Kami Quick Reference

A complete, cumulative list of every combination “Key,” for use at the table. Each higher version includes all combinations from the previous versions: CASUAL (5pts capital) → INITIATES (10pts) → CHAMPIONS (15pts) → MASTERS (20pts).

Two exceptions to stacking: The Apples Pears and the Hearts / Silver / Earth Hands never stack with each other. Likewise, the Small Path and the Long Path never stack either. O/C: Open or Closed Hand — C: Closed Hand required — O: Open Hand required. All O/C combinations earn 1pt extra if achieved with a Closed Hand, with the exception of the Stream and the Favors.

Key	Pts	Scope	Introduced
Winning Draw	1pt	C	CASUAL
The Favors	1pt	O/C	CASUAL
The Stream	1pt	O/C	CASUAL
The Small Path	1pt	O/C	CASUAL
The Two Oaks	1pt	O/C	CASUAL
The Kami	2pts	C	CASUAL
The Oak Grove	2pts	O/C	CASUAL
The River	1pt	C	INITIATES
The Two Maples	2pts	O/C	INITIATES
Left Bank Right Bank	2pts	O/C	INITIATES
The 5 Pairs	3pts	C	INITIATES
The Apples Pears	2pts	O/C	CHAMPIONS
The Prestige	3pts	O/C	CHAMPIONS
The Winding Path	3pts	O/C	CHAMPIONS
The Long Path	3pts	O/C	CHAMPIONS
The Great Road	3pts	O/C	CHAMPIONS
The Small Jack	4pts	O/C	MASTERS
The Small Queen	4pts	O/C	MASTERS
The Maple Grove	6pts	C	MASTERS
The Hearts Hand	5pts	O/C	MASTERS
The Silver Hand	5pts	O/C	MASTERS
The Earth Hand	5pts	O/C	MASTERS
The Grand Queen	10pts	O/C	MASTERS
The Grand Jack	10pts	O/C	MASTERS
The Grand Prestige	10pts	O/C	MASTERS
The Court	10pts	O/C	MASTERS
The Council of Sages	10pts	C	MASTERS
Kamiwaza 神業	15pts	O/C	MASTERS
Kami no Kumon 神の九門	15pts	O/C	MASTERS

Descriptions and worked examples for each Key are detailed earlier in this rulebook, in the “Combinations ‘Keys’ and Points” section.

+1pt Trump per Trump card present in the hand.

+1pt Under Indicator per card present in the hand — only on a Kami victory.

Kami — List of Keys

Each combination present in the winning hand earns a fixed number of points. These combinations can be stacked with one another.

Two exceptions to stacking: The Apples Pears and the Hearts/Silver/Earth Hands never stack with each other. Likewise, the Small Path and the Long Path never stack either.

O/C : Open or Closed Hand. C : Closed Hand Required. O : Open Hand Required.

All O/C Combinations earn 1pt extra if achieved with a Closed Hand, with the exception of the Stream and the Favors.

Version each combination is introduced in: **CASUAL** (5pts) **INITIATES** (10pts) **CHAMPIONS** (15pts) **MASTERS** (20pts) — each higher version includes all combinations from the previous versions.

Winning Draw — 1pt

Draw the winning card. C

CASUAL

The Favors — 1pt

A Triplet of Queens / or a Triplet of the Turn Jack (same suit as the Trump) / or a Triplet of your Position. O/C (All stack together.) No Bonus for Closed Hand.

CASUAL

The Stream — 1pt

A hand made up only of cards from 2 to 8. O/C No Bonus for Closed Hand.
ex: 2♦3♦4♦ 4♣5♣6♣ 5♦6♦7♦ 2♥2♥

CASUAL

The River — 1pt

Runs only, double wait, ordinary pair. C (A Double Wait is when the missing card can be one of two cards that complete a Run. Ex: 2♥3♥ in hand — either 1♥ or 4♥ can complete the Run.)

INITIATES

The Small Path — 1pt

A Run in two identical copies. O/C
ex: 1♥2♥3♥ 1♥2♥3♥ 4♦4♦4♦ J♣/♣

CASUAL

The Two Oaks — 1pt

The same Triplet in two suits. O/C
ex: 3♥3♥3♥ 3♣3♣3♣ 4♦4♦4♦ J♣/♣

CASUAL

The Kami — 2pts

Declare "Kami" by staking 1pt (the hand must be Waiting). C

CASUAL

☛ Kami can only be declared if, at that moment, the awaited card — or at least one of the awaited cards, in case of a multiple wait — is not present in any discard pile.

The Oak Grove — 2pts

Only Triplets. O

CASUAL

The Two Maples — 2pts

Two Concealed Triplets (the rest of the hand may be open). O/C

INITIATES

Left Bank Right Bank — 2pts

Every element of the hand contains Terminals or Honors. O/C
ex: 1♥2♥3♥ 7♣8♣9♣ Q♥Q♥Q♥ 9♣9♣

INITIATES

The Apples Pears — 2pts

A single suit plus Honors. O/C
ex: 1♥2♥3♥ 9♥9♥9♥ Q♦Q♦Q♦ 8♥8♥

CHAMPIONS

The 5 Pairs — 3pts

5 pairs + one card identical to a card in one of the Pairs. C
ex: 1♥1♥/♣/♣ 5♣5♣ 9♦9♦ 6♥6♥ 5♣

INITIATES

The Prestige — 3pts

Only Terminals or Honors. O/C
ex: 1♦1♦1♦ 9♣9♣9♣ J♦/♦J♦ Q♥Q♥

CHAMPIONS

The Winding Path — 3pts

The same Run in three suits. O/C
ex: 1♥2♥3♥ 1♣2♣3♣ 1♦2♦3♦ 4♣4♣

CHAMPIONS

The Long Path — 3pts

A Run in two identical copies + the same Run in another suit. O/C
ex: 1♥2♥3♥ 1♥2♥3♥ 1♣2♣3♣ 4♣4♣

CHAMPIONS

The Great Road — 3pts

123456789 in a single suit + any pair. O/C

CHAMPIONS

The Small Jack — 4pts

Two Triplets of Jacks + a pair of the third. O/C

MASTERS

The Small Queen — 4pts

Two Triplets of Queens + a pair of the third. O/C

MASTERS

The Maple Grove — 6pts

Three Concealed Triplets. C

MASTERS

— Grand Hands —

The Hearts Hand — 5pts

A hand made only of cards from the Hearts suit (no Honors). O/C

MASTERS

The Silver Hand — 5pts

A hand made only of cards from the Diamonds suit (no Honors). O/C

MASTERS

The Earth Hand — 5pts

A hand made only of cards from the Clubs suit (no Honors). O/C

MASTERS

The Grand Queen — 10pts

A Triplet of each Queen. O/C

MASTERS

The Grand Jack — 10pts

A Triplet of each Jack. O/C

MASTERS

The Grand Prestige — 10pts

Only Terminals. O/C
ex: 1♥1♥1♥ 9♦9♦9♦ 9♥9♥9♥ 1♣1♣

MASTERS

The Court — 10pts

Only Honors. O/C
ex: Q♣Q♣Q♣ J♥/♥J♥/♥ J♦/♦J♦ Q♥Q♥

MASTERS

The Council of Sages — 10pts

Ten different cards among the 12 Terminals/Honors + one Double. C
ex: Q♥J♥1♦9♦1♣9♣Q♣/♣1♥9♥Q♥

MASTERS

Kamiwaza 神業 — 15pts

Cards from a single suit (including Honors) with the following cards:
1♣2♣3♣4♣5♣6♣7♣8♣9♣J♣Q♣. O/C

MASTERS

Kami no Kumon 神の九門 — 15pts

Cards from a single suit with the following cards:
1♥1♥2♥3♥4♥5♥6♥7♥8♥9♥9♥. O/C

MASTERS

+1 pt Trump, per Trump card present in the hand.

+1 pt Under Indicator per card present in the hand — only on a Kami victory.